



City of Cambridge

COF 2026-87
FIRST IN COUNCIL
June 9, 2026

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

A handwritten signature in cursive script, reading "Paula M. Crane".

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

A communication was received from Pardis Saffari, Director of Economic Opportunity and Development, transmitting the meeting agenda and overview of innovation spaces.

Economic Development and University Relations Committee - Startup and Innovation Ecosystem Roundtable

June 9, 2026

Agenda

Welcome by City Manager Yi-An Huang

Attendee Introductions:

- i. Emily Knight, The Engine
- ii. Maggie O'Toole, LabCentral
- iii. Tim Rowe and Denyse Medlenkda, CIC
- iv. Ankit Gupta, Y Combinator

Conversation Questions:

1. What's going well in Cambridge's innovation ecosystem? What strengths are you seeing across your organizations and the companies you support?
2. Where do you see chances to build on Cambridge's strengths, or grow its competitive edge, and what challenges or emerging risks do you think could get in the way?
3. What actions from the City – policy, infrastructure, partnerships, or other support – would meaningfully help this ecosystem?

Cambridge Incubators & Coworking Spaces

Cambridge is home to a variety of coworking and incubators, but in particular three major innovation incubators—CIC, The Engine, and LabCentral—that collectively anchor the city’s startup ecosystem and support thousands of jobs. These organizations serve different but complementary roles across the tech, biotech, and tough-tech sectors, helping early-stage companies grow from idea to commercialization. Together, they provide specialized environments, networking, and community connections that help early-state companies build relationships essential for accessing capital and scaling their ventures.

Cambridge Innovation Center (CIC)

Founded in Cambridge in 1999, CIC has grown into a global leader in flexible innovation space, now operating more than 1.5 million square feet across North America, Europe, and Asia. In Cambridge, CIC runs two Kendall Square locations that support both emerging startups and established national and international companies. As of 2025, these facilities housed 702 companies employing 5,432 people. CIC is also home to the first Venture Café, a weekly entrepreneurship gathering that has hosted more than 774 events and welcomed 218,200 visitors. <https://cic.com/cambridge/>

The Engine

The Engine is a nonprofit incubator and accelerator dedicated to supporting early-stage “Tough Tech” companies—startups working on breakthrough technologies in areas such as climate, energy, infrastructure, and biotech. Its Cambridge facilities provide specialized infrastructure, including labs, engineering and fabrication shops, office space, and meeting rooms. As of 2025, The Engine supported 130 companies employing 1,100 people. Since its founding, current and alumni teams have raised \$5.5 billion and the organization hosted over 210 workshops, trainings, and ecosystem events. Resident companies span a mix of sectors, including Advanced Systems & Infrastructure (45%), Climate & Energy (21%), and Life Sciences & Biotech (34%). <https://engine.xyz/>

LabCentral

LabCentral is a nonprofit shared lab environment for early-stage biotech and life science innovators. It operates 210,000 square feet of space across Cambridge and Boston, including pre-seed lab facilities, biomanufacturing space, and a shared program with the Bayer Research and Innovation Center. As of 2025, LabCentral hosted 86 companies employing 508 people in its Cambridge sites. Since 2013, LabCentral companies have collectively raised \$21.85 billion, launched 171 clinical trials, enrolled 17,421 patients, received 1,846 patents, and created 7,915 new life sciences jobs. In 2025 alone, LabCentral hosted 500 educational and training events with 13,880 attendees, reinforcing its role in both life science entrepreneurship and workforce development. <https://www.labcentral.org/>

Y Combinator

Y Combinator (YC) is a highly influential startup accelerator and venture capital firm founded in 2005 here in Cambridge before moving to Silicon Valley. It has helped launch over 5,000 companies, including Airbnb, Dropbox, and Reddit. It runs for four cohorts over the year that run three months at a time. <https://www.ycombinator.com/>